It was an astonishing display of public condemnation. Sri Lanka has seen many mass uprisings since it gained independence from the British in 1948. But never has a popular leader been ousted the way its President Gotabaya Rajapaksa was recently. As streets heaved with angry protesters, lakhs stormed the presidential residence, called the Queen's House, in the historic Colombo Fort. Rajapaksa was forced to flee Colombo and take refuge in the Maldives. On July 13, a state of emergency was declared in the country and Prime Minister Ranil Wickremesinghe was made acting president till a new one was elected by Parliament on July 20. Yet the troubles are far from over and Sri Lanka, crippled by a series of crisis, lies on the brink of economic collapse and political anarchy.

Ironically, both Gotabaya Rajapaksa and his brother, Mahinda, who was till recently prime minister, were hailed as heroes for defeating the feared Tamil Tigers, till both had to resign as protests grew across the country. So what led to their denouement? As former US President Bill Clintons' advisers put it, "It's the economy stupid". It was the mismanagement of the economy that sealed the fate of the powerful Rajapaksa clan. It began almost as soon as Gotabaya won the presidential election in November 2019. To fulfil a poll promise, he offered extremely generous tax cuts, which the public were told would stimulate growth, but subsequently led to loss of revenue running into billions of rupees.

Then, the pandemic hit in March 2020 and the country was pushed into extended lockdown. But before the economic shock set in, in the parliamentary polls held in August 2020, the Sri Lanka Podujana Peramuna (SLPP), the party controlled by the Rajapaksa family, won with a sizeable majority and Mahinda took over as PM. But soon, the pandemic's impact set in. Sri Lanka's economy is heavily dependent on tourism, but with the industry crashing it incurred massive loss of revenue. Inward remittances from Lankan workers overseas, the other major revenue source, dropped significantly too.

Instead of reintroducing the reduced taxes, Gotabaya took the ill-informed and misguided step of moving the country toward organic farming and stopped the import of chemical fertilisers, crippling farmers and reducing crop yields, which led to a backlash from rural Sri Lanka—the vote base of the Rajapaksas. Prices of essential goods began to soar, with a shortfall in the supply of the country's staple rice and vegetables forcing the government to import rice. Foreign reserves, too, fell drastically due to the bad economic policies taken by Gotabaya and his acolytes, who till early this year parroted arrogant claims that the economy was on a sound footing and repeatedly rejected calls by the opposition as well as economists to urgently seek a bailout from the International Monetary Fund (IMF).

It was only in April this year that Gotabaya woke to the reality that his policies had dragged the country into an economic abyss—he admitted publicly that his government had erred by banning the use of fertilisers and by turning its back on the IMF. By then daily power cuts and shortages of fuel, domestic gas and medicine had bit into Lankans' lives, and they were weighed down by soaring prices of essential goods. Thus began protests calling for Gotabaya and Mahinda to step down—first as candlelit vigils in the suburbs of Colombo and growing into a bigger people's movement. The GotaGoHome campaign, as it came to be known, began to pick up towards the end of April, with protesters camping outside the presidential secretariat in Colombo.

A LEADERLESS REVOLUTION

The turning point came on May 9, when supporters of Mahinda turned on peaceful protesters, leading to outrage and his hasty resignation as prime minister. The backlash against the Rajapaksas and their supporters was brutal—several ruling party supporters, including a lawmaker, was killed and over 80 of their properties burnt by mobs. With that, the GotaGoHome (GGG) movement began to gather strength. The GGG campaign was initially youth driven, with university students in the vanguard, but given the economic hardship faced by the entire population, including the country's complacent middle class, trade unions, social activists and professionals began to throw in their lot with the protests. Hundreds of volunteers began to rally around those who had camped outside the president's office, bringing food and other supplies, while musicians and artists joined in to keep their morale high. Well-known Sri Lankan cricketers like Sanath Jayasuriya and Roshan Mahanama were among those who supported calls for the president's resignation. One unique feature of the movement is that it has remained leaderless throughout, with several groups working with a common objective of ousting the president and bringing about political reform that would give more power to the people and less to politicians.

After Mahinda was forced out of office, a beleaguered and